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## Losing Language

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## 1 General Revisions

- Edits from the marked up pdf
- Notes from mom’s reading of the essay
  - flesh out main idea of essay “thinking without language”
    - \* Perhaps more examples of *how* I do this
  - review/rewrite the conclusion/ending
- Peer Review Notes
  - improve transitions (probably with a focus on the last one)

## 2 Revision Strategies

- Emotional Mapping
  - See the notes section of each paragraph
- Compression and Expansion
- Figurative/Indirect Language (Stunning Sentences)

## **3 Essay**

### **3.1 Moment 1-1**

The first time I ever lost my language I was sitting outside, in the middle of the morning, working on math homework. Working with numbers on a screen, I had no idea I would not be able to speak, read, or even think with the full vocabulary I was accustomed to; the only clue I had was for some reason numbers were disappearing from my vision when I looked at them wrong. I remember walking inside, going through the kitchen and finding my mom in the living room. I tried to tell her about what was going on with my vision, but was surprised (and quite scared) to find that instead of the words I wanted to say, coming out of my mouth was gibberish, with maybe the hint of one or two actual words.

#### **3.1.1 Notes**

**NOTE**

- Emotional mapping
  - Surprise & fear directly referenced
  - A little bit of confusion described

### **3.2 Moment 1-2**

Rushing to my room I grabbed a book, and, running back out to the living room I discovered along with gibberish coming out from my mouth, gibberish was also coming in through my eyes; I could no longer recognize any of the words on the page, or even begin to try pronouncing them.

### 3.2.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping
  - It doesn't feel like any emotions are described or referenced here
  - I want it to give/invoke feelings of light terror/fear though
    - \* perhaps something about the loss of the skill of reading & after "words on the page,"?

## 3.3 Moment 1-wrap up

Although later I would come to enjoy and even wish for more of this experience, at the time it was possibly one of the most terrifying things I ever went through. I was 100% sure I was having a stroke and thought I would never be able to speak or read properly again. ~~Sitting in the E.R. I remember trying to feel out the "damage" and imagine how I would continue to live without language.~~ **Sitting in the E.R. I remember racking my brain, trying to feel out "damage", searching desperately for how I would continue to live without the majority of my language.** Through this process of finding what I could ~~and couldn't~~ **still** do/~~did and didn't know~~, I realized, ~~or~~ started to realize, two things: how vital language was for my life (I use it constantly, both for things necessary and for most things fun), and that places existed where it was not as vital or necessary as I had previously thought.

### 3.3.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping

- Terror directly referenced
- “Sitting in”-“without language.” feels to logical/accepting/practical, doesn’t convey the right sense.
  - \* needs more like desperation almost (less, “hm, how will I keep going”, more “oh my god please can I still do this, please let me be able to continue doing this thing.”)
  - \* I specifically remember trying to imagine a “for” loop, to see if I could still program, or if that would be something taken from me forever.
    - (ctx: computer stuff & programming [was/is] like one of the main things I do for fun)

- Expansion

- Expand on this process of feeling out the “damage” to convey better how it felt in the moment.

### 3.4 Complex Migraine brief context

I first began to have complex migraines (now called migraines with aura) a few years ago, right before I started high school. A complex migraine is generally a migraine with an aura phase containing stroke-like symptoms before the pain of the migraine phase.

#### 3.4.1 Notes

**NOTE**

- Emotional Mapping

- No emotions here really, though I don't think it needs any. This mostly just serves to give a little bit of context.

### 3.5 Transition Moment 1 to 2

While this first was perhaps the most dramatic, I continued to have complex migraines (and still do) although they appeared quite infrequently, and with almost no rhyme or reason. However for the rest, unlike the first, I knew what I was dealing with, and instead of terrifying losses of language they became exciting ~~losses of language~~ moments of freedom from it, which helped me grow into how I use language now.

#### 3.5.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping
  - Excitement is directly referenced.
  - I want this to describe a sense of excitement, and sense of freedom

### 3.6 Moment 2

One of these later migraines I distinctly remember, as it helped me deepen my understanding of my relationship between language and thought.

I was outside, barefoot, and up in a pine tree when I began to notice one of the antennas on some roof seemed to be flickering in and out of reality. This threw me for a bit, before I realized what was going on and recognized I was having another complex migraine. While the prospects of the migraine part were not something I looked forward too, at the moment I was mostly

excited for the “complex” part. As it was, I decided up in a tree was not the best place to experience disappearances in my vision, and as I prepared myself to explore my mind I made my way down the tree. As I climbed down, my language began to disappear,~~although~~. Despite this, I found myself still able to think and picture things clearly; I conjured up images, remixed memories, and connected them all with metaphor. I soon realized though, all these images and thoughts, without language, were being washed away, like sticks and leaves in a storm. Seeing this led me to believe that language was like the scaffolding that holds ideas in place and fixes them there, and not necessarily the thing that helps them form or even makes them up (although it can be). Later on, this image would join hands with another and help me use language as freely as I want to, without all the constraints it (or I) impose.

### 3.6.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping
  - Excitement is directly mentioned
  - The last section of the paragraph gives a slight hopeful feeling
- Expansion
  - On the ways of thinking without language
  - “things clearly” - add a sentence on how?
    - \* combination & remixing of memory & image, metaphor
- Figurative Language

### 3.7 Transition/Intro to Moment 3

As these migraines continued to pop up ever so infrequently, I made my way into high school, and took some of what I consider my first “real” writing courses, in this case, AP Language & Composition. At this point I had taken a few writing classes before and could tell that the major struggle for me was the actual use of language itself; I felt I had to write only “A” quality work or it wasn’t worth it (even though I knew otherwise), and would often get hung up in the very first steps of writing a draft and idea generation. I had a few strategies to get around this (primarily changing the medium, e.g. writing with a dip pen), but they were not always consistent.

#### 3.7.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping
  - No strongly described emotions
  - Possible hook for describing how major struggle felt
    - \* How felt: frustrated
    - \* This doesn’t feel necessary for the essay as a whole

### 3.8 Moment 3

One such time I (mostly) clearly remember, I was working on a short essay talking about the book “Foundation” by Isaac Asimov, and I was getting nowhere. Although I knew I had some ideas in my head, I could not get them out; I was too focused on getting the language and structure just right. Eventually, I had a sort of epiphany (although the true realization



came after), and I ~~gave up almost completely~~ almost completely gave up on writing with “real” language and structure. I knew that language gives ideas structure ~~and lets more complex thoughts happen~~ but this structure was also exactly what was giving me trouble, I it needed the words to be exact and precise. So I tried using the most basic structure I knew ~~how~~, and let my words just leave breadcrumbs, ~~just~~ tracking my ideas as I made my way through them. Minimizing the language I used, to maximize my ideas and the speed with which I illuminated them. Like I was painting with watercolor, filling in broad strokes, rather than ~~filling in all the small details with a fine tip pen and getting all the lines to connect just right.~~ using a fine-tip pen, filling in all the small details and getting all the lines to connect /just/ right. Eventually, I had a very crude ~~almost~~ pseudo-list of “sentences”, with only the most basic relations. But that very crude structure contained most of my idea and let me see it all at once and rework it into something much better.

### 3.8.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping
  - Slight description of frustration
  - The second half slightly gives the feeling of renewed energy
- added quotes to title

### 3.9 New Transition/Wrap up?

NEW

As I continued to live and think and write, and my skill with language continued to grow, I also worked to retain and improve my skill without language, or more specifically my skill at thinking without language. While it may have first sprung from my complex migraines and flexed its muscles for the first time thinking about language, it became another tool I use as I move through the world, just like language.

#### 3.9.1 Notes

NOTE

- the end feels like it might stray from the most central point
- I could mention meditation's role here, but I don't think it quite fits.

### 3.10 Conclusion

Through all of these experiences I was able to see past the empire of language, and into the lands beyond. Having this access and view helped me see my own language and how *I* use it, especially in academic contexts where I to struggle with perfectionism. Being able to see that languages was not all consuming almost allowed me to break through those barriers of perfectionism I had constructed. ~~Now that language wasn't everything~~ and I could side-step the problem of only trying to write the perfect combinations of words by avoiding words entirely while blocking out ideas.

#### 3.10.1 Notes

NOTE

- Emotional Mapping

- gives looking forward and backwards hopefully